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A Qualitative Examination of Precautionary Measures in a Virtual Reality Fear Environment

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Abstract
Americans take a myriad of safety precautions each day to prevent victimization, a costly and often time-consuming practice. Most of what we know about precautionary measures comes from the fear of crime literature. Previous studies typically examine precautionary measures in relation to fear of crime and ask respondents about behaviors they engaged in or avoided retroactively. Our research team put precautionary measures at the forefront by creating a virtual reality (VR) subway station where 105 participants entered a subway station, selected items to take with them on a train and selected a bench to wait for their train. The items included traditional precautionary measures (pepper spray, knife) and everyday items (cell phone, book, headphones, car keys). We also placed VR characters on a bench and asked participants to select a bench near or far from the characters. Participants were asked to explain their decision-making process. We learned that individuals engaged in avoidance and protective behaviors and our results found the decision-making process in the selection of these measures were complex and unique. The results of our study can help public safety agencies design public spaces so that individuals feel safer in these spaces.

Keywords Fear of Crime · Precautionary Measures · Virtual Reality · Qualitative

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